Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
    a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.

    In Egypt I did not have access to food so it was very hard there. The difference was very big. Here you can buy everything you need. In Egypt there were a lot of things I couldn't get, when I went to the doctors they told me I had extreme nutrition insecurity. I buy halal meats, chicken, vegetables, fruits. Sometimes I cook the beef with tomato and onions. Something simple. Sometimes I make soup with beef with onion as well. I eat it with a little bit of rice. I make pasta sometimes.

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
    a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

    I take 290 for food stamps and its not enough for me. I buy halal meats and its just not enough for me.I worry at the 20th of the month that the food I have is not going to last. So I worry from the 20th until the day my EBT is recharged for me to use. The food that I can get is too little. The amount that I get is too little. I buy from smiths, or Walmart, and for Arabic foods I buy it from specialty market. Sometimes someone will come and take me but if I walked to specialty its 15 minutes. I go to Shahrazad to buy halal meat.

        i. Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

    b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

    I tried to ask the organization for the human rights. I told them I was running out of food and they told me that they can not help me out. After that I did not try again.

    FQ: Does IRC still help you?

No they told me to take my case to human rights. (this is a lin assumption but I believe he might be taking about DWS when he says human rights organization)

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?
IRC used to help me with cleaners only but now they stopped.
   i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.
   ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

They used to take me to appointments. They also used to show me where I can buy things which helped me out.

   iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?
   iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

d. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?

When I feel like I am going to run out it feels like a problem. This happens every month. Like I told you the food I have is not enough.

FQ: when did you realize that the amount you would get in food stamps would not be enough?

I've known from when I first got here. By the second month I told them the amount I get was not enough for me. They told me these are governmental laws and they can not change the amount I get.

e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:
SNAP
   i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?
   IRC applied for me, I did not do anything. They brought me the card for the food stamps. I do not know any details.
   FQ: if I asked you to apply for food stamps yourself, would you be able to?
   No
   ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.
   It's a good program but the amount I get is too little. If I got more it would be better.
   iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

I buy sugar, tea, coffee, and things like that. Halal beef and chicken, rice and vegetables and fruits.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

100%

Repeat i-iv for other programs they have used.

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

    To maintain my health and to continue life.

    FQ: do you feel more comfortable mentally and physically eating food from your cultures?

    Yes If I was able to eat as I wanted I would be comfortable.

    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

    I can find them at Walmart or smiths.

    I get beans to cook with meat which is something that is a Sundanese food that I can make here. I have to find those at specialty market.

    c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

    They helped me get to the places, but they didn't help me get the food.

        i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

    d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

    No

    e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

    No

FQ: why have you not gone to a food pantry or anything like that?

First of all, to get to places alone is hard. A lot of people are busy so I might not find anyone to take me places.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

If there was a delivery service to deliver food to houses, if they were able to help in that way it would be good. It would help those who have disabilities to get food.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

    Maybe not knowing of them. There are a lot of stuff that you mentioned that I just did not know about. IRC only told us about food stamps, but they didn't tell us about food pantries or churches like you mentioned.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

Maybe, informing them of places that can help. After that they can get help from places. First of there is a language barrier. There aren't people to tell us where you can get help, gaining information is not accessible for those who need it.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

   They will not help you with food. I personally have not received help when it comes to food with them. They help you with paper work and appointments things like that. But they haven't helped me with food.

   FQ: what do you think they can do to help you in regards to food?

   They can show me places that can help. They can show me places that can help me with food assistance. If they can't take me at least they can tell me about them. They don't have to take me, they can just inform me where it is.

   FQ: do you think there is a language barrier when buying groceries?

   There are things that are hard. I have to call people and tell them that I want this specific thing. They will talk to the worker that's available to help me get the groceries. There are translators at IRC that help but sometimes I call him outside of his work hours and he still helps me.Sometimes I ask him to take me to places.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   There is nothing else other than the things that I said already.

   FQ: What do you wish IRC can do to help you now that you've graduated?

   Right now I wish that they would finish my application for a green card and things like that. I applied for that with them since June and I have not received anything that the paperwork has been approved or that they even got them. I don't even know who to contact to ask about the status of my green card application.